

Pseudogapping parameters*

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1 Introduction

This talk concerns *gapping* and *pseudogapping* (PG) (Levin 1979):

(1) English

a. Gapping

John **should eat** three apples, and Mary [~~should eat~~] four oranges.

b. PG

John should **eat** three apples, and Mary should [**eat**] four oranges.

Chinese languages have constructions resembling gapping and PG (Wei 2008):¹

(2) Mandarin

a. Gapping-like construction

Zhangsan **yinggai chi** san ge pingguo. Lisi Δ si ge juzi.

Zhangsan should eat three CLF apple Lisi four CLF orange

'Zhangsan **should eat** three apples. Lisi [**should eat**] four oranges.'

(Tang 2001: 202, with 'should' added)

b. PG-like construction

Zhangsan yinggai **chi** san ge pingguo. Lisi yinggai Δ si ge juzi.

Zhangsan should eat three CLF apple Lisi should four CLF orange

'Zhangsan should **eat** three apples. Lisi should [**eat**] four oranges.'

(3) Cantonese

a. Gapping-like construction

Zoengsaam **jinggoi sik** saam go pinggwo. Leisei Δ sei go caang.

Zoengsaam should eat three CLF apple Leisei four CLF orange

'Zoengsaam **should eat** three apples. Leisei [**should eat**] four oranges.'

b. PG-like construction

Zoengsaam jinggoi **sik** saam go pinggwo. Leisei jinggoi Δ sei go caang.

Zoengsaam should eat three CLF apple Leisei should four CLF orange

'Zoengsaam should **eat** three apples. Leisei should [**eat**] four oranges.'

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¹ Glossing abbreviations follow the Leipzig Glossing Rules with this addition: SFP = sentence-final particle.

We advance the view in (4).²

(4) *First part of the proposal*

- a. Chinese gapping-like construction $\neq$ English gapping.
- b. Chinese PG-like construction $\neq$ English PG.
- c. Chinese gapping-like construction = Chinese PG-like construction = empty verb.
- d. Chinese does not allow a movement plus deletion derivation of gapping and PG.

With regard to the function of the empty verb, we propose that it is a pair-list copula in the sense of Li 2025, albeit phonologically null:

$$(5) \llbracket \emptyset_{\text{pair-list}} \rrbracket^c = [\lambda y. \lambda x. f^c(x) = y]$$

English PG is typically understood to involve moving the remnant (Move-R) followed by VP ellipsis (VPE) (e.g., Jayaseelan 1990):

(6) *Derivation of English PG*

John should **eat** three apples, and Mary should [four oranges]_i ~~[eat t_i]~~.



If the view in (4) is true, then as a language that allows Move-R and VPE, Chinese raises a question of why it does not allow two mechanisms combined:

- (7) How is it the case that the following three claims hold simultaneously?
- a. English allows PG, composed of Move-R and VPE; while
 - b. Chinese allows Move-R and VPE, but
 - c. Chinese disallows PG.

In response to this question, we propose (8).

(8) *Second part of the proposal*

The availability of PG in a language results from a conspiracy of multiple “parametric” settings, which include:

- a. the availability of VPE;
- b. the availability and type of Move-R; and
- c. the [E] feature specification of Foc⁰.

² From this point onward, everything stated for Mandarin applies equally to Cantonese, and we use *Chinese* to refer to both languages. To save time, Cantonese examples are not provided in the main text but can be found in Appendix A.

Roadmap

- ii. Move-R plus deletion vs. empty verb
- iii. Phonologically null pair-list copula
- iv. PG typology
- v. Conclusion

2 Move-R plus deletion vs. empty verb

While PG is typically understood to involve Move-R followed by VPE, gapping has received multiple analyses:

- (9) *Large conjunct and Move-R plus deletion* (e.g., [Depiante 2000](#), [Boone 2014](#))

John **should eat** three apples, and Mary₁ [four oranges]₂ [_{TP} t₁ ~~should eat~~ t₂].

- (10) *Small conjunct and Move-R plus deletion* (e.g., [Coppock 2001](#), [Lin 2002](#))

John₁ **should** [_{XP} [_{VP} t₁ **eat** three apples]], and [_{XP} Mary₂ [four oranges]₃ [_{VP} t₂ ~~eat~~ t₃].

- (11) *Small conjunct and ATB verb movement* (e.g., [Johnson 1994, 2009](#), [Tang 2001](#))

John₁ **should eat**₂ [_{VP} t₁ t₂ three apples], and [_{VP} Mary t₂ four oranges].

- (12) *In-situ and selective spellout* (e.g., [Broekhuis 2018](#))

John **should eat** three apples, and Mary [_{TP} ~~should eat~~ [four oranges]_F].

- This talk focuses on the Move-R plus deletion analyses (9–10), but the data may pose challenges for extending the other analyses to Chinese as well.
- In what follows, we present three groups of data that distinguish between the following two kinds of analyses of Chinese gapping-like and PG-like constructions.

- (13) a. *Move-R plus deletion*

Lisi (should) [four CLF orange]₁ [_{eat} t₁].

(cf. [Cao 2014](#), [Ye 2024](#))

- b. *Empty verb*

Lisi (should) ∅_{pair-list} four CLF orange.

(cf. [Tang 2001](#))

2.1 Adjunct exclusion

English VPE and PG omit verbal adjuncts:

(14) *English VPE*

- a. Mary hasn't **secretly dated** Bill, but Sue has [~~secretly dated~~ Bill], #though not secretly.
- b. John should **quietly eat three apples**, and Mary should [~~quietly eat three apples~~], too.

(15) *English PG*

- a. Mary hasn't **secretly dated** Bill, but Sue has [~~secretly dated~~] John, #though not secretly. (Jayaseelan 1990: 64, adapted)
- b. John should **quietly eat** three apples, and Mary should [~~quietly eat~~] four oranges.

Chinese VPE also omits verbal adjuncts:

(16) *Mandarin VPE*

Zhangsan yinggai **manman** chi san ge pingguo. Lisi ye yinggai Δ.
 Zhangsan should slowly eat three CLF apple Lisi also should
 'Zhangsan should **slowly eat three apples**. Lisi should [**slowly eat three apples**], too.'

However, Chinese gapping-like and PG-like constructions do not omit adjuncts:

(17) a. *Mandarin gapping-like construction*

Zhangsan yinggai **manman** chi san ge pingguo.
 Zhangsan should slowly eat three CLF apple
 Lisi Δ si ge juzi.
 Lisi four CLF orange

'Zhangsan **should slowly eat** three apples.
 Lisi [**should (*slowly) eat**] four oranges.'

b. *Mandarin PG-like construction*

Zhangsan yinggai **manman** chi san ge pingguo.
 Zhangsan should slowly eat three CLF apple
 Lisi yinggai Δ si ge juzi.
 Lisi should four CLF orange
 'Zhangsan should **slowly eat** three apples.
 Lisi should [**(*slowly) eat**] four oranges.'

(18) Zhangsan keyi yikouqi **zuo** wushi ge fuwocheng.

Zhangsan can in.one.go do fifty CLF push.up
 Lisi keyi Δ yibai ge, buguo zhongjian yao xiuxi yi xia.
 Lisi can one.hundred CLF but in.between need take.a.break one time
 'Zhangsan can **do** fifty push-ups in one go.
 Lisi can [**do**] one hundred, but he needs to take a break in between.'

2.2 Resultative suffixes

Verbs with resultative suffixes *-de* (19) or *-dao* can be deleted.

- (19) (Zhe zhi wu,) Zhangsan (keyi) **tiao-de** hen haokan,
 this CLF dance Zhangsan can dance-RES very beautiful
 er Lisi que (keyi) Δ hen nankan.
 and Lisi however can very ugly
 ‘(This dance,) Zhangsan **dances/can dance** very beautifully,
 but Lisi [**dances**]/[**can dance**] in a very ugly manner.’

However, resultative complements cannot move to a preverbal position:³

- (20) *Zhangsan [hen haokan]₁ (keyi) tiao-de t₁.
 Zhangsan very beautiful can dance-RES
 Intended: ‘Zhangsan dances/can dance very beautifully.’

2.3 PG-like construction–licensing heads

Modals, some preverbal aspects (21a), and control verbs (21b) license VPE in Chinese (e.g., Lee & Pan 2024).

- (21) a. *Mandarin preverbal aspect: ✓VPE*
 Zhangsan you **manman chi san ge pingguo**. Lisi ye you Δ .
 Zhangsan PFV slowly eat three CLF apple Lisi also PFV
 ‘Zhangsan **slowly ate three apples**. Lisi did [**slowly eat three apples**], too.’
- b. *Mandarin control verb: ✓VPE*
 Zhangsan xiang **manman chi san ge pingguo**.
 Zhangsan want slowly eat three CLF apple
 Lisi ye xiang Δ .
 Lisi also want
 ‘Zhangsan wants to **slowly eat three apples**.
 Lisi wants to [**slowly eat three apples**], too.’

A preverbal aspect does not allow Move-R to the preverbal position within its complement (22a), but a control verb does (22b).

³ We do not consider this a knock-down argument, as we need to allow movements exclusive to ellipsis contexts for English PG anyway.

(22) a. *Mandarin preverbal aspect: ✗Move-R*

*Zhangsan you [san ge pingguo]_i manman chi t_i.
 Zhangsan PFV three CLF apple slowly eat
 Intended: 'Zhangsan slowly ate three apples.'

b. *Mandarin control verb: ✓Move-R*

Zhangsan xiang [san ge pingguo]_i manman chi t_i.
 Zhangsan want three CLF apple slowly eat
 'Zhangsan wants to slowly eat three apples.'

- One might expect control verbs to allow PG(-like constructions), but not preverbal aspects.
- The prediction is borne out for preverbal aspects, but not control verbs, which turn out to disallow PG-like constructions:

(23) *Mandarin control verb: ✗PG-like construction*

Zhangsan xiang (**manman**) **chi** san ge pingguo.
 Zhangsan want slowly eat three CLF apple
 (*Lisi xiang Δ si ge juzi.)
 Lisi want four CLF orange
 'Zhangsan wants to (**slowly**) **eat** three apples.
 (*Lisi wants to [(**slowly**) **eat**] four oranges.)'

Moreover, some other modals like *neng* 'can' do not allow PG-like constructions, either:

(24) *Mandarin neng 'can': ✗PG-like construction*

Zhangsan neng (**manman**) chi san ge pingguo.
 Zhangsan can slowly eat three CLF apple
 (*Lisi neng Δ si ge juzi.)
 Lisi can four CLF orange
 'Zhangsan can (**slowly**) **eat** three apples.
 (*Lisi can [(**slowly**) **eat**] four oranges.)'

(25) a. Zhangsan yinggai **chi** san wan. Lisi yinggai Δ wu wan.

Zhangsan should eat three bowl Lisi should five bowl
 'Zhangsan should **eat** three bowls (of rice). Lisi should [**eat**] five bowls (of rice).'

(Wei 2008: 82)

b. Zhangsan neng **chi** san wan. (*Lisi neng Δ wu wan.)

Zhangsan can eat three bowl Lisi can five bowl
 'Zhangsan can **eat** three bowls (of rice). (*Lisi can [**eat**] five bowls (of rice).)

(cf. Ye 2024)

	‘Should’/keyi ‘can’	Neng ‘can’	Control verb	Pre-V Asp
VPE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Move-R	✓	✓	✓	✗
PG-like construction	✓	✗	✗	✗

Table 1 Chinese VPE-licensing heads

3 Phonologically null pair-list copula

A phonologically null copula naturally captures the observations in the table. Modals like ‘should’ and *keyi* ‘can’ contrast with control verbs, preverbal aspects, and modals like *neng* ‘can’ in whether they can be immediately followed by a copula:

- (26) a. *‘Should’: ✓ Copula*
 Zhangsan yinggai shi chi san ge pingguo.
 Zhangsan should COP eat three CLF apple
 ‘Zhangsan should eat three apples.’
- b. *Neng ‘can’, control verb, or preverbal aspect: ✗ Copula*
 *Zhangsan neng/xiang/you shi chi san ge pingguo.
 Zhangsan can want PFV COP eat three CLF apple
 Intended: ‘Zhangsan can eat/wants to eat/ate three apples.’

As for the semantics of the copula, we suggest Li’s (2025) pair-list copula:

$$(27) \llbracket \text{shi}_{\text{pair-list}} \rrbracket^c = [\lambda y. \lambda x. f^c(x) = y] \quad (\text{Li 2025: 44})$$

This copula is originally proposed for its use in pair-list answers (cf. Dayal 2002, 2016):

- (28) Na ge laoshi jiao na men ke?
 which CLF teacher teach which CLF class
 ‘Which teacher teaches which class?’ (Li 2025: 2)
- a. Zhang laoshi jiao Yingwen. Li laoshi jiao shuxue.
 Zhang teacher teach English Li teacher teach math
 ‘Teacher Zhang teaches English. Teacher Li teaches Math.’
- b. Zhang laoshi shi Yingwen. Li laoshi shi shuxue.
 Zhang teacher COP English Li teacher COP math
 ‘Teacher Zhang teaches English. Teacher Li teaches Math.’ (Li 2025: 2)

4 PG typology

- The analysis proposed in sections 2 and 3 is in favor of the position that Chinese does not allow PG.

- This section aims to provide an account for why Chinese might lack PG, while it does allow Move-R and VPE.

4.1 Japanese PG

- Japanese is argued to allow PG, alongside verb raising out of the ellipsis site (Kim 1997, Funakoshi 2016, Tanaka & Hayashi 2018).
- Evidence includes the recoverability of VP adjuncts (29), similar to English VPE.

(29) *Japanese*

John-wa NYU-ni-wa **han-toshi ryūgaku** su-ru-ga,
 John-TOP NYU-at-TOP half-year study.abroad do-NPST-but
 MIT-ni-wa Δ shi-na-i.
 MIT-at-TOP do-NEG-NPST
 ‘John will **study abroad for half a year** at NYU,
 but he won’t [**study abroad for half a year**] at MIT.’ (Tanaka & Hayashi 2018: 5)

- We adopt Johnson’s (2008) view that Move-R in English PG is overt QR and attribute the lack of English-style PG in Chinese to its lack of overt QR (at least for nominals, cf. Lee 2022).
- We adopt Tanaka & Hayashi’s (2018) view that Japanese Move-R is focus movement (30) and discuss why Chinese disallows Japanese-style PG in the next subsection.

(30) *Derivation of Japanese PG*

[TP [FocP MIT-at-TOP₁ {VP t₁ half-year study.abroad t₂}] do₂-NEG-NPST]

4.2 FocP licensing parameter

The absence of Japanese-style PG in Chinese can be accounted for by Lee’s (2023) FocP licensing parameter (31), assuming that focus movement lands in a FocP that takes the VP to be elided as its complement.

(31) *FocP licensing parameter proposed in Lee 2023*

- | | |
|--|-----------------|
| a. A FocP is only licensed by a covert complement. | <i>Japanese</i> |
| b. A FocP is only licensed by an overt complement. | <i>Chinese</i> |

This can be implemented as a distinction in the feature specification of focus heads.

- Japanese Foc^o must bear [E], whereas Chinese Foc^o must not.
- Since Chinese Foc^o does not bear [E], it cannot elide its complement after Move-R.

(32) *Chinese Foc^o complement unelidable* $\rightsquigarrow$ $\nexists$ PG

*want [_{FocP} [this cup milk]₁ [_{VP} slowly drink ~~t₁~~]]



- This distinction in Foc^o's feature specification is independently motivated by the observation that right dislocation (RD) of focused constituents is allowed in Japanese (33) but not in Chinese (34).
- We can treat RD of focused constituents as involving movement of the dislocated element to FocP followed by ellipsis in the second conjunct (35) under a biclausal analysis à la Yip 2025 a.o.

(33) *Japanese*

Kaet-te ki-ta yo inu-dake-wa.
return-and come-PST SFP dog-only-TOP
'Only the dog came back.'

(Nakagawa, Asao & Nagaya 2008: 5)

(34) *Chinese*

a. *Focus without RD: OK*

Zhiyou wo mai-le zhe ben shu la.
only 1SG buy-PFV this CLF book SFP
'Only I bought this book.'

b. *No focus in RD: OK*

Mai-le zhe ben shu la wo.
buy-PFV this CLF book SFP 1SG
'I bought this book.'

c. *Focus in RD: **

*Mai-le zhe ben shu la zhiyou wo.
buy-PFV this CLF book SFP only 1SG

Intended: 'Only I bought this book.' (Lee 2023: 467, translated into Mandarin)

(35) *Chinese Foc^o complement unelidable* $\rightsquigarrow$ $\nexists$ focus in RD

*[_{TP} {~~only~~ 1SG} buy-PFV this CLF book SFP] [_{FocP} [only 1SG]₁ [_{TP} t₁ ~~buy-PFV this CLF book SFP~~]]



4.3 Full proposal

We argue that the (un)availability of PG in a language results from the interaction of multiple syntactic factors, including:

- the (un)availability of VPE;
- the (un)availability of overt QR;

- the (un)availability of focus movement; and
- whether Foc^0 bears [E].

Their interaction is illustrated in the table that follows, where empty cells indicate that the settings do not impact PG's availability.

Type (example)	I (English)	II (Japanese)	III (Chinese)	IV	V
VPE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗
Move-R	✓overt QR	✓focus movement	✓focus movement	✗	
Foc^0 with [E]		✓	✗		
PG	✓	✓	✗	✗	✗

Table 2 PG parameters

5 Conclusion

Takeaways

- Chinese gapping-like and PG-like constructions are not derived by Move-R plus deletion but by an empty pair-list copula.
- Chinese lacks English-style PG because it disallows overt QR, and it lacks Japanese-style PG because its Foc^0 must not bear [E].

A Cantonese data

(36) Cantonese VPE

a. 'Should': OK

Zoengsaam jinggoi maanmaan sik saam go pinggwo.

Zoengsaam should slowly eat three CLF apple

Leisei dou jinggoi Δ.

Leisei also should

'Zoengsaam should **slowly eat three apples**.

Leisei should [**slowly eat three apples**], too.'

b. Control verb: Also OK

Zoengsaam soeng maanmaan sik saam go pinggwo.

Zoengsaam want slowly eat three CLF apple

Leisei dou soeng Δ.

Leisei also want

'Zoengsaam wants to **slowly eat three apples**.

Leisei wants to [**slowly eat three apples**], too.'

(37) *Cantonese PG-like construction*

a. *'Should': OK*

Zoengsaam jinggoi **sik** saam go pinggwo. Leisei jinggoi Δ sei go pinggwo.
Zoengsaam should eat three CLF apple Leisei should four CLF apple
'Zoengsaam should **eat** three apples. Leisei should [**eat**] four apples.'

b. *Control verb: **

Zoengsaam soeng **sik** saam go pinggwo. (*Leisei soeng Δ sei go pinggwo.)
Zoengsaam want eat three CLF apple Leisei want four CLF apple
'Zoengsaam wants to **eat** three apples. (*Leisei wants to [**eat**] four apples.)'

(38) *Cantonese copula*

a. *'Should': OK*

Zoengsaam jinggoi hai sik saam go pinggwo.
Zoengsaam should COP eat three CLF apple
'Zoengsaam should eat three apples.'

b. *Control verb: **

*Zoengsaam soeng hai sik saam go pinggwo.
Zoengsaam want COP eat three CLF apple
Intended: 'Zoengsaam wants to eat three apples.'

(39) *Cantonese RD*

a. *Focus without RD: OK*

Zinghai ngo maai-zo ni bun syu zaa3.
only 1SG buy-PFV this CLF book SFP
'Only I bought this book.'

b. *No focus in RD: OK*

Maai-zo ni bun syu zaa3 ngo.
buy-PFV this CLF book SFP 1SG
'I bought this book.'

c. *Focus in RD: **

*Maai-zo ni bun syu zaa3 zinghai ngo.
buy-PFV this CLF book SFP only 1SG
Intended: 'Only I bought this book.'

(Lee 2023: 467)

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